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FACULTY OF EDUCATION SCIENCES
PEDAGOGY OF NATIONAL AND FOREIGN LANGUAGES

Trabajo de Integración Curricular previa la
obtención del Grado Académico de
Licenciado en Pedagogía de los Idiomas
Nacionales y Extranjeros.

PROYECTO DE INVESTIGACIÓN

**ENHANCING SPEAKING SKILLS OF BEGINNER LEVEL STUDENTS THROUGH
THE CO-TEACHING METHOD IN EFL CLASSROOMS**

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PPA 2025-2026

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INTRODUCTION

CHAPTER I

CONTEXTUALIZATION OF THE RESEARCH

1.1. Research problem

1.1.1. Problem Statement

In the context of the Ecuadorian public education system, beginner-level students in English as a Foreign Language (EFL) classrooms encounter significant obstacles in the development of oral proficiency. These challenges are predominantly rooted in systemic issues, including overcrowded classrooms, severely limited instructional time, and a persistent reliance on traditional teaching methodologies that prioritize grammar and writing over authentic spoken communication. As a direct consequence, many students demonstrate low levels of fluency, a notable lack of confidence, and minimal active participation in English-speaking activities.

This situation creates a critical disparity between the national curriculum's stated objective of fostering communicative competence and the functional abilities students actually acquire. The learning environment often fails to provide sufficient opportunities for verbal interaction, personalized feedback, or the real-world language practice necessary to build oral skills effectively. Students are consequently hindered in their ability to use English in meaningful contexts, which is the ultimate goal of language acquisition. This research, therefore, addresses the pressing need to explore and evaluate the co-teaching method as a potential solution to overcome these pedagogical barriers, aiming to foster an interactive and supportive classroom environment where beginner students can genuinely enhance their speaking skills.

1.1.2. Problem formulation

To what extent does the implementation of the co-teaching method affect the development of speaking among beginner-level EFL students?

1.1.3. Systematization of the problem

What are the theoretical foundations that support the “co-teaching classroom” as a holistic solution for addressing the complexities of speaking skill acquisition within the specific pedagogical context of the Ecuadorian educational system?

How does the implementation of foundational co-teaching strategies influence the engagement and participation of beginner-level EFL students in oral communication tasks?

What is the measurable progression of students' speaking skills following a co-teaching-based intervention, as determined by pre- and post-assessment instruments?

How do the final speaking skill outcomes of the student group that received the co-teaching intervention compare to those of the control group taught using traditional solo-teaching methods?

1.2. OBJECTIVES

1.2.1. General Objective:

To enhance the speaking skills of beginner-level students, in terms of fluency, pronunciation, and communicative confidence, by implementing and analyzing the influence of the co-teaching method in an EFL classroom.

1.2.2. Specific Objectives:

To construct the theoretical rationale for proposing the “co-teaching classroom” as a holistic solution for EFL instruction by synthesizing research on foundational co-teaching models, the complexities of speaking skill acquisition, and the specific pedagogical challenges within the Ecuadorian educational system.

To measure the influence of foundational co-teaching strategies on beginner-level EFL students’ engagement and participation in oral communication tasks, through systematic observation and assessment during implementation

To determine the progression of student’ speaking skills through co-teaching-based interventions, using pre- and post-assessment tools such as audio recordings, rubric-guided observations, and student self-reflection reports

To compare the final speaking skill outcomes of the co-teaching intervention group against those of a control group taught via traditional solo-teaching methods.

1.3. JUSTIFICATION

The justification for this research is founded on pressing pedagogical, practical, and theoretical needs within the Ecuadorian EFL context. The ability to communicate effectively in English is a fundamental skill in an interconnected world, yet the development of oral proficiency remains a significant and persistent challenge for students in Ecuador's public schools. There exists a critical gap between the national curriculum's mandate for communicative competence and the classroom reality, where overcrowded settings, limited instructional time, and traditional methods often leave speaking skills underdeveloped. This study is necessary because it directly confronts this long-standing issue by investigating a practical, student-centered methodology designed to foster the very skills that are currently neglected.

This research is particularly timely and relevant due to the emergence of co-teaching as a promising pedagogical model to address these specific barriers. Co-teaching provides a dynamic framework for increasing student opportunities for verbal interaction, receiving personalized feedback, and engaging in authentic language practice, key elements often missing in a traditional solo-teacher classroom. Furthermore, collaborative teaching models are already being implemented in some Ecuadorian schools, such as those supported by non-governmental organizations. Therefore, this study is not merely theoretical; it seeks to evaluate and provide empirical evidence for a strategy that has practical application within the national context, offering a pathway to optimize existing resources and collaborations.

The findings of this investigation are poised to offer significant contributions to multiple stakeholders. Primarily, beginner-level students stand to benefit from a more engaging and effective instructional approach that builds their communicative confidence, fluency, and willingness to participate. For educators and school administrators, this study will provide a research-validated framework for implementing co-teaching, offering insights into how to structure lessons that effectively enhance oral skills in resource-constrained environments. Finally, this research will add valuable empirical data to the existing body of literature on EFL pedagogy in Ecuador, potentially informing teacher training programs and future curricular development aimed at improving speaking proficiency nationwide.

CHAPTER II

THEORETICAL BASIS OF THE RESEARCH

2.1. Conceptual framework

This conceptual framework defines and contextualizes the theoretical pillars that support the study on enhancing the oral skills of beginner-level students through the co-teaching method in EFL classrooms. To achieve this objective, research from three fundamental pillars is synthesized: the foundational models of co-teaching, the inherent complexities of oral skill acquisition, and the specific pedagogical challenges of the Ecuadorian educational system. The articulation of these perspectives is essential to validate the co-teaching model as a contextualized and robust response to the current needs of English language teaching in Ecuador.

2.1.1. *English as a Foreign Language (EFL)*

English as a Foreign Language (EFL) refers to the study of English in a non-Anglophone country where it is not the primary medium of daily life or instruction. This context is common in many educational systems, such as those in East Asia, which were designed to address "perceived shortcomings for local public school English education, where classes were generally taught by local teachers using their first language (L1) as the medium of instruction" (Kim & Moodie, 2023). The fundamental challenge in EFL environments is the limited exposure students have to the target language outside the classroom, making the quality and nature of classroom instruction paramount for language acquisition. The ultimate goal in these settings is to develop learners' proficiency to enable communication in a globalized world where English often serves as a lingua franca.

The instructional reality of EFL classrooms is often marked by significant pedagogical challenges. Many general education and content-area teachers "often admit their lack of understanding of ELLs' sociocultural, linguistic, academic, or emotional needs" (Dove & Honigsfeld, 2010). This feeling of unpreparedness is compounded by the fact that teaching is frequently characterized by a sense of professional seclusion, where "individual teachers invent their own practice in isolated classrooms" (Elmore, 2000, as cited in Dove & Honigsfeld, 2010, p. 5). This isolation can hinder the development of effective strategies needed to support language learners, highlighting the necessity for collaborative pedagogical models that can provide teachers with shared expertise and support.

From a modern pedagogical perspective, the goal of EFL education extends beyond the mere acquisition of linguistic skills. The Council of Europe (2020) advocates for an "action-oriented approach," which reframes the learner as a "social agent" who actively co-

constructs meaning through interaction. This vision moves away from a deficiency-based model and promotes a "proficiency" perspective guided by "can do" descriptors that focus on what learners are capable of achieving in real-life communicative situations. The overarching aim is to foster a holistic plurilingual and pluricultural competence, where the learner develops a dynamic and interrelated linguistic repertoire rather than mastering a language in isolation. This approach values the learner's entire linguistic and cultural background as a resource for learning and communication.

Achieving these ambitious goals in an EFL setting requires a shift in instructional delivery from isolated, traditional methods to integrated, collaborative practices. This transition involves moving away from a "20th Century Paradigm," where language support is treated as a separate, remedial intervention, toward a "21st Century Paradigm". In this updated model, "ALL teachers share responsibility for ALL students," and language specialists become integrated members of the instructional team, working alongside content teachers to develop both language and academic knowledge simultaneously. This collaborative approach ensures that language learning is contextualized and directly supports students' access to the broader curriculum, making the educational experience more coherent and effective for every learner in the classroom.

2.1.2. Speaking skills

Speaking is a fundamental productive skill in language acquisition, serving as the primary vehicle for oral communication and human interaction. It is defined as a complex, active, and productive ability that allows individuals to express information and convey meaning verbally in a coherent manner (Subba Dewan & Dev Sharma, 2025; Kiruthiga & Christopher, 2022). In the context of second language learning, speaking is often the skill most prioritized by learners, as it directly reflects their capacity to use the language for practical purposes in diverse, real-world situations (Alvarez et al., 2024). Unlike receptive skills, speaking requires learners to produce language spontaneously and instantly, making it a demanding yet essential component of communicative competence (Subba Dewan & Dev Sharma, 2025).

The production of spoken language is a sophisticated cognitive process that involves the simultaneous coordination of multiple mental mechanisms. According to Levelt's (1989) model, this process consists of three main stages: conceptualization, where the speaker selects the intended meaning and information to be conveyed; formulation, which involves

choosing the appropriate vocabulary and grammatical structures to frame the message; and articulation, the physical production of speech sounds through the articulatory organs (Fatehi Rad et al., 2016). The inherent complexity of managing these processes in real-time often results in learners experiencing hesitations, grammatical inaccuracies, and a limited vocabulary as they develop their proficiency ((Fatehi Rad et al., 2016).

Oral proficiency is commonly evaluated based on two key components: accuracy and fluency. Accuracy refers to the extent to which a learner's speech conforms to the established norms of the target language, encompassing the correct use of grammar, vocabulary, and pronunciation. Fluency, conversely, is characterized as the ability to produce spoken language smoothly and naturally, linking units of speech together without undue pauses, strain, or hesitation (Fatehi Rad et al., 2016). While distinct, these two components are often interdependent; an over-emphasis on accuracy may hinder fluency, while a sole focus on fluency can lead to a lack of grammatical precision.

Ultimately, speaking is an interactive and social act, not merely an individual performance. Its effectiveness is deeply intertwined with listening, as speakers must actively perceive their interlocutor's contributions to respond appropriately and negotiate meaning (Alvarez et al., 2024). Therefore, developing the speaking skill involves more than mastering linguistic components; it requires an understanding of how to use language appropriately within specific social and cultural contexts to build rapport, manage conversations, and achieve communicative goals effectively (Subba Dewan & Dev Sharma, 2025)

2.1.3. The condition of the beginner level student

The linguistic profile of a beginner-level English as a Foreign Language (EFL) student is fundamentally marked by performance-related challenges, stemming from a nascent and developing language system. Learners at this initial stage often struggle to express themselves effectively, not necessarily due to a complete absence of knowledge, but because of psychological barriers and an inability to retrieve and utilize the vocabulary they possess (Leong & Ahmadi, 2017). Their oral production is often characterized by a high degree of hesitation and frequent pauses, as they must consciously search for appropriate words and construct sentences, a process that is not yet automatized (Hellas et al., 2023). This condition underscores the necessity of instructional approaches that build confidence and provide ample opportunities for low-stakes practice to bridge the gap between passive knowledge and active use.

Affective factors, such as anxiety, motivation, and self-confidence, are exceptionally influential in the early stages of language acquisition. For beginners, the fear of making errors and the pressure of performing in front of peers can create significant psychological obstacles that inhibit their willingness to speak (Afebri et al., 2019). These emotional barriers can manifest as a reluctance to participate in classroom activities, directly impacting the quantity and quality of their oral practice (Abbas Falah Alzubi et al., 2025). Consequently, a primary condition for enabling progress in beginner students is the cultivation of a supportive and low-anxiety learning environment where they feel secure enough to experiment with the language, even with their limited proficiency (Hoang et al., 2015).

From a cognitive standpoint, the process of speaking for a beginner is demanding, often involving a conscious and slow translation from their native language rather than direct thought in English. This mental translation process consumes significant cognitive resources, resulting in speech that is slow and lacks fluency (Afebri et al., 2019). Furthermore, their listening comprehension, a crucial skill for interaction, is frequently underdeveloped. This makes it difficult for them to process incoming speech in real-time, which in turn limits their ability to formulate appropriate responses, creating a cyclical challenge where comprehension deficits impede oral production (Fatehi Rad et al., 2016).

Linguistically, the knowledge of a beginner is constrained by an insufficient vocabulary and a fragile grasp of grammatical structures, leading to frequent errors in production (Afebri et al., 2019). The most common difficulties arise from a lack of mastery over basic sentence patterns, incorrect word choices, and the negative transfer of phonological and structural rules from their first language (L1) (Shamim Akhter, 2021). These interlingual errors, such as mispronouncing sounds that do not exist in their native tongue or applying L1 grammatical patterns to English, are hallmark characteristics of this proficiency level. Addressing these specific linguistic gaps through targeted instruction is therefore essential for building a solid foundation for future learning (Aini et al., 2022).

2.1.4. The Co-Teaching Method as a Pedagogical Intervention

The co-teaching method, also known as collaborative teaching, is defined as a pedagogical intervention in which "two or more professionals deliver substantive instruction to a diverse, or blended, group of students in a single physical space" (Cook & Friend, 1995). This seminal definition has become the foundation for understanding this model, which spans collaboration between general and special education teachers, as well as between

content-area teachers and English as a Second Language (ESL) specialists. Co-teaching requires that educators not only share a classroom but also ideally collaborate on all facets of the educational process. This instructional model envisions a close working relationship between teachers, which includes joint lesson planning, delivering instruction through a variety of shared roles, assessing student work, and reflecting on their practice to enhance the effectiveness of both educators (Guise et al., 2023).

The fundamental rationale for implementing co-teaching lies in its potential to improve learning opportunities for all students within an inclusive classroom. By having two teachers in the same space, the model aims to "increase instructional options for all students," enhance the intensity and continuity of the program, reduce the stigma for students with special needs, and increase professional support for the teachers themselves (Cook & Friend, 1995). This collaboration allows two or more educators to collectively accomplish what would normally be the responsibility of a single individual, resulting in more resources being available to students (Roth et al., 2000). This structure effectively lowers the student-teacher ratio, exposing students to differentiated teaching methods and creating more opportunities for engagement. In the context of second language acquisition, co-teaching exposes learners to authentic language and fosters greater oral interaction, which can significantly enhance their communication skills (Abdallah, 2009).

To guide the practical implementation of this method, several models have been developed to structure the interaction and distribution of responsibilities between teachers. These models provide a framework for how co-teachers can effectively work together in the classroom. The most commonly recognized approaches include:

- **One Teach, One Assist:** In this model, one teacher takes the lead on instruction while the other circulates the room to provide individual support to students.
- **Station Teaching:** The instructional content is divided into different stations, and students rotate between them. Teachers are responsible for facilitating learning at specific stations, which may also include an independent work station.
- **Parallel Teaching:** The class is split into two smaller, heterogeneous groups, and each teacher delivers the same content to one of the groups simultaneously.

- **Alternative Teaching:** One teacher works with a small group on a different lesson or activity, for pre-teaching, re-teaching, or enrichment, while the other instructs the larger group.
- **Team Teaching:** In what is considered the most interdependent model, both teachers actively share the delivery of instruction to the entire class, often engaging in conversational-style teaching.

These models have been adapted and expanded for specific contexts, such as ESL instruction. For instance, Dove and Honigsfeld (2010) expanded the framework to include variations like "One Teach, One Assess," and further distinguished alternative teaching approaches. The choice of a particular model typically depends on student needs, the content being taught, and the collaborating teachers' styles and preferences. Recent research indicates that regardless of the variety of models available, the "one teach, one assist" approach remains predominant in many classrooms, although "team teaching" is also utilized by pairs who have developed a stronger collaborative dynamic (Kim & Moodie, 2023). Flexibility is crucial, and experienced co-teaching pairs often use multiple approaches, sometimes shifting from one to another within a single lesson.

The success of any co-teaching model ultimately hinges on the quality of collaboration between the educators. It is not merely the presence of two teachers in a room but a professional partnership where planning, instruction, and assessment are truly shared responsibilities. Effective collaboration requires teachers to communicate openly, negotiate their roles, and establish a shared vision for teaching and learning. However, research has shown that collaboration in co-teaching exists along a spectrum, ranging from "no collaboration to full collaboration, with different levels of engagement" (Kim & Moodie, 2023). This spectrum includes levels such as marginal collaboration (minimal participation), intermittent (occasional involvement), uncoordinated (efforts are not synchronized), somewhat coordinated (teamwork with limited integration), and full collaboration (a fluid and integrated partnership). To reach higher levels of collaboration, it is essential for institutions to provide administrative support, dedicated joint planning time, and professional development to prepare teachers for this demanding yet rewarding mode of instruction.

2.1.5. The “Co-teaching Classroom”

The proposed “co-teaching classroom” is conceptualized as a holistic pedagogical model designed to address the unique challenges of English as a Foreign Language (EFL) instruction within the Ecuadorian educational system. This framework defines the co-teaching classroom as an environment of complete pedagogical flexibility, where two educators collaborate to provide students with their full attention, thereby enriching and individualizing the learning process. This model directly responds to systemic issues prevalent in many Ecuadorian public schools, such as overcrowded classrooms, a lack of student motivation, and limited opportunities for authentic oral practice (Pusd Montenegro, 2021). By integrating established co-teaching principles with a focus on communicative competence, this model serves as a transformative intervention aimed at empowering both students and teachers. The theoretical rationale for this model is built upon a synthesis of foundational co-teaching structures, an understanding of the complexities of second language acquisition, and a direct response to the pedagogical needs observed in the Ecuadorian context.

At its core, the co-teaching classroom is grounded in the principle of professional collaboration as a means to enhance instructional quality and support diverse learners. Co-teaching is a service delivery option where two or more certified professionals share ownership, instructional responsibilities, and accountability for a single group of students in a shared workspace (Colson et al., 2021). The fundamental rationale for this approach is its capacity to increase instructional options for all students, improve program intensity, and provide greater professional support for teachers (Cook & Friend, 1995). In this model, the collaboration is a formal structure where instructors "fully participate in all elements of the teaching, including course design, instruction, and assessment before, during, and after the course" (Haag et al., 2023). This partnership serves as a powerful lever for pedagogical change, moving away from traditional, isolated teaching methods toward evidence-based, student-centered practices (Haag et al., 2023). The synergy created by two educators allows them to pool their expertise, such as a content specialist and a language specialist, to create a more dynamic and responsive learning environment.

The pedagogical flexibility of the co-teaching classroom is achieved through the implementation of various instructional models that allow teachers to adapt to the specific needs of their students and the learning objectives of a lesson. These structures provide a

practical framework for sharing instructional responsibility and lowering the student-teacher ratio.

The strategic use of these models allows educators to be highly adaptive, creating multiple pathways for students to engage with the material and receive targeted support. This flexibility is essential for addressing the diverse proficiency levels and learning styles found in a typical Ecuadorian EFL classroom (Pusd Montenegro, 2021).

For this model to be effective, it must transition from a traditional, hierarchical "20th Century Paradigm," where a specialist pulls students out for isolated instruction, to a "21st Century Paradigm" built on shared responsibility. In this modern approach, "ALL teachers share responsibility for ALL students," and the ESOL teacher becomes an integrated language specialist who collaborates with content-area colleagues to develop both language and content skills for every learner (Mulazzi & Nordmeyer, 2012). This requires a deep, collaborative partnership, which is more than just sharing physical space. It is a professional relationship that exists on a spectrum, ranging from minimal interaction to full, integrated collaboration where planning, teaching, and assessment are seamlessly co-constructed (Kim & Moodie, 2023). Achieving this level of synergy is critical for the holistic functioning of the co-teaching classroom, as it ensures that the presence of two teachers translates into a genuinely enhanced learning experience.

The co-teaching classroom is particularly well-suited to address the complexities of speaking skill acquisition in an EFL context. Oral proficiency, which encompasses both interaction and production (Council of Europe, 2020), is a primary goal of language learning but is often neglected in traditional classroom settings due to large class sizes and limited opportunities for individual practice. The co-teaching model directly mitigates these challenges. By implementing models like station teaching or parallel teaching, educators can create smaller, more manageable groups where students feel more comfortable participating orally (Cook & Friend, 1995). This increased interaction time is crucial for developing fluency, accuracy, and confidence. Furthermore, the presence of two teachers provides students with more varied linguistic models and greater opportunities for authentic, real-time feedback, thereby creating a richer language environment (Pusd Montenegro, 2021).

Finally, the "co-teaching classroom" functions as a powerful, job-embedded model for professional development, which is essential for sustaining pedagogical improvement in the Ecuadorian context, particularly in rural or under-resourced areas. Co-teaching is not just

an intervention for students; it is a "pedagogical development strategy" for teachers (Haag et al., 2023). When educators collaborate, they are exposed to different teaching philosophies, develop new skills, and engage in critical reflection about their practice, making it a "welcome byproduct of collaboration" (Mulazzi & Nordmeyer, 2012). This ongoing, contextualized professional learning has been shown to significantly improve teachers' self-efficacy in student engagement, instructional practices, and classroom management (Colson et al., 2021). By fostering a culture of collaboration, the co-teaching classroom empowers teachers to build upon each other's strengths and collectively meet the diverse needs of their students, making it a truly holistic and sustainable solution for enhancing EFL education in Ecuador.

2.2. Reference framework

2.2.1 Referential Framework for Co-Teaching

Co-teaching is grounded in the principle of professional collaboration as a pedagogical strategy to respond to student diversity within a single learning environment. This method, which has gained popularity in various educational systems, is defined as an instructional delivery model in which "two or more professionals jointly deliver substantive instruction to a diverse or blended, group of students in a single physical space" (Cook & Friend, 1995, as cited in PUSDÁ Montenegro, 2021, p. 2). The model extends beyond the mere presence of two teachers in a classroom; it implies a formal partnership where the responsibilities of planning, instruction, and assessment are shared, with the goal of improving the academic performance and skills of all students (Murawski, 2003, as cited in (PUSDÁ Montenegro, 2021).

The rationale for this model lies in its capacity to transform traditional classroom dynamics, which often present challenges such as large class sizes and a lack of individualized attention. By combining the styles and strengths of two educators, such as a local teacher and a native-speaking volunteer, co-teaching "increases the possibilities to support students in the classroom" (PUSDÁ Montenegro, 2021, p. 17). This synergy not only benefits students by providing them with more resources and attention but also enriches the teachers, fostering self-confidence, academic skill development, and a positive professional relationship (Walther-Thomas, 1997, as cited in PUSDÁ Montenegro, 2021). In the context of

English as a Foreign Language (EFL), this approach is particularly valuable as it creates an environment that boosts the learning process and encourages authentic oral interaction.

For its practical implementation, co-teaching is not conceived as a rigid method but as a flexible approach that materializes through various strategies or models. These models allow teachers to adapt instruction to the specific needs of students and the objectives of each lesson (Murawski, 2003, as cited in Pusedá Montenegro, 2021). The research highlights six main models, based on the work of Friend (2014):

1. **One Teach, One Observe:** One teacher leads the instruction for the whole group while the other focuses on observing and collecting data on student behavior or social interaction. This information is valuable for analyzing and planning future pedagogical interventions.
2. **Station Teaching:** The content and students are divided into several learning stations or centers. The teachers facilitate instruction at different stations while one group may work independently. This model encourages small-group work and keeps students focused and motivated.
3. **Parallel Teaching:** The class is divided into two groups, and each teacher delivers the same lesson simultaneously to each half. This strategy maximizes student participation and allows for better classroom management, although the groups do not rotate.
4. **Alternative Teaching:** One teacher works with the majority of the class while the other attends to a small group to offer differentiated instruction, either for remediation or enrichment, using different materials or approaches.
5. **Team Teaching:** Considered a model of high collaboration, both teachers deliver the lesson together to the entire class. They exchange roles fluidly and support each other during instruction, acting as a cohesive team.
6. **One Teach, One Assist:** One teacher assumes the lead instructional role, while the second acts as an assistant, supporting students with their questions, managing behavior, or distributing materials. This model allows for more personalized guidance.

The application of these models in the EFL classroom, especially with the collaboration of native-speaking volunteers, creates a conducive environment for the development of oral skills. The reduction of the student-to-teacher ratio in models like station teaching or parallel teaching allows students to overcome barriers such as shyness and participate more actively. This methodology aligns with communicative and cooperative approaches, where interaction and the meaningful use of language are fundamental for second language acquisition. In summary, co-teaching presents itself as a comprehensive framework that not only addresses the logistical limitations of the classroom but also effectively and motivationally enhances the development of students' communicative competence.

2.3. Legal Framework

This research, focused on improving oral skills in the English language through the co-teaching method, is anchored in a robust Ecuadorian legal framework that prioritizes the right to a quality, inclusive, participatory, and intercultural education. The current regulations, from the Constitution of the Republic to specific ministerial agreements, provide the foundation for the implementation of innovative pedagogical methodologies that respond to the needs of students and promote the integral development of their communicative competencies.

2.3.1. Constitution of the Republic of Ecuador (2008)

The Magna Carta establishes the guiding principles upon which the national education system is built and which support this study:

Article 26: Consecrates education as a "right of persons throughout their lives and an unavoidable and inexcusable duty of the State." This fundamental principle obligates the State to guarantee the conditions for all citizens to access an education that, as detailed in subsequent articles, must be of high quality and relevance. The search for effective methods such as co-teaching directly responds to this mandate.

Article 27: Stipulates that education "shall be centered on the human being and shall guarantee their holistic development." Furthermore, it defines it as "participatory, compulsory, intercultural, democratic, inclusive and diverse, of quality and warmth." This article justifies the adoption of pedagogical models such as co-teaching, which by its

collaborative nature fosters participation, addresses diversity in the classroom, and actively seeks to improve the quality of pedagogical interaction.

Article 347, Numeral 1: States as a responsibility of the State to "Strengthen public education and co-education; ensure the permanent improvement of quality, the expansion of coverage, physical infrastructure, and the necessary equipment for public educational institutions." The implementation and evaluation of new teaching methodologies is a direct path for the continuous improvement of educational quality.

2.3.2. Organic Law of Intercultural Education (LOEI)

This law operationalizes the constitutional mandates and guides pedagogical management in the country, offering direct support to the objectives of this thesis:

Article 2, literal w: Within the aims of education, it establishes the importance of "promoting the development of information and communication technologies [...] as a support to the teaching-learning process." While not limited to co-teaching, this article promotes a focus on supports and methodologies that enrich traditional teaching practice.

Promotion of Pedagogical Innovation: The LOEI, as a whole, promotes a flexible and dynamic educational system. Its spirit encourages institutions and teachers to research, adapt, and implement strategies that respond effectively to classroom challenges, such as the development of oral competence in a foreign language. Co-teaching aligns with this principle of innovation and continuous improvement.

2.3.3. Specific Ministerial Agreements

Public policy regarding the teaching of foreign languages has materialized in agreements that support the need to strengthen communicative competencies in English:

Ministerial Agreement No. 0052-14: This agreement established the mandatory teaching of the English language from the second grade of Basic General Education to the third year of Bachillerato in all educational institutions in the country. This provision underscores the relevance that the State places on the learning of this language and, consequently, the need to ensure the effectiveness of its teaching, justifying research on methodologies that, like co-teaching, pursue this goal.

Ministerial Agreement No. MINEDUC-ME-2016-00020-A: Through this agreement, the curriculum for the levels of basic general education and bachillerato was established. The Foreign Language curriculum is focused on the development of the four

macro-skills (listening, speaking, reading, and writing) under a communicative approach. This implies that the methodologies applied in the classroom must prioritize the functional and practical use of the language, a central objective of the co-teaching method proposed in this thesis to enhance oral production.

2.3.4. Code for Children and Adolescents

This legal body reinforces the right to a quality education from the perspective of students' rights:

Article 37: Recognizes the "right to a quality education" for all children and adolescents. It defines that this must "respect the cultures and specificities of each region and place" and "develop their potentialities and skills for their integration and participation on equal terms." The implementation of co-teaching, by allowing for more individualized attention adapted to different learning paces, is a concrete strategy to materialize this right to an education that addresses the particular needs of each student.

In summary, the Ecuadorian legal framework not only allows but encourages the exploration and implementation of pedagogical models such as co-teaching. By defining education as a fundamental right oriented towards integral development, quality, and inclusion, and by establishing the mandatory and communicative approach for the teaching of English, the current regulations provide a solid basis that fully justifies the present research and its objectives.

CHAPTER III
RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1. Location

We conducted this study at the Escuela de Educación Básica "Víctor Manuel Rendón," a public school located in the city of Valencia, province of Los Ríos, Ecuador. I deliberately selected this setting because it is representative of the typical conditions and challenges prevalent within the Ecuadorian public education system, such as overcrowded classrooms and limited opportunities for speaking practice.

This educational environment was characterized by factors that directly impact English as a Foreign Language (EFL) instruction. These conditions, including limited resources, often restrict the amount of instructional time dedicated to developing students' oral skills, creating a context where traditional teaching methods prevail and authentic speaking practice is scarce. Therefore, the school provided a realistic and relevant environment in which to implement and evaluate the co-teaching method as a potential solution to these systemic challenges, with the goal of generating findings applicable to similar EFL contexts across the country.

3.2. Types of Research

For this research, we adopted a concurrent mixed-methods design. This methodology allowed us to simultaneously collect and analyze both qualitative and quantitative data in order to gain a more comprehensive understanding of the co-teaching phenomenon in English language acquisition. We firmly believe that this synergy of data offers a more complete and nuanced perspective than either approach could provide on its own.

The qualitative dimension of this study was anchored in an action research model. We selected this approach to directly tackle the key challenge: improving speaking skills in a real classroom environment. This model was descriptive and exploratory, allowing for an in-depth examination of the co-teaching process as it naturally occurred. It operated through a reflective cycle of planning, acting, observing, and reflecting, which enabled continuous adjustments to the teaching strategies based on real-time classroom dynamics and student needs.

The quantitative component provided an objective framework for measuring the intervention's outcomes. This approach focused on collecting numerical data through pre- and post-test assessments to statistically measure the changes in students' speaking proficiency. Specifically, it sought to quantify improvements in fluency, accuracy, and confidence, allowing for a clear comparison between the experimental and control groups.

By integrating these two research types, we were able to not only measure the effectiveness of the co-teaching method but also understand the contextual factors that influenced its success.

3.3. Research methods

In alignment with the mixed-method design, this study integrated both inductive and deductive research methods to guide the collection and analysis of data. The combination of these methods allowed for a dynamic approach where we could explore the complexities of the classroom environment while simultaneously testing a specific hypothesis. This dual approach ensured that the research findings were both contextually rich and empirically grounded.

For the quantitative portion of the research, we used the deductive method. This method begins with a specific hypothesis, which is then tested through the collection of empirical data. Our study was initiated with the hypothesis that implementing the co-teaching method would significantly enhance the speaking skills of beginner-level EFL students. To test this, we collected numerical data from pre- and post-test assessments, measuring specific variables such as fluency and vocabulary use. This structured approach allowed us to systematically evaluate the intervention's effectiveness and determine if the observed improvements were statistically significant, thereby confirming or refuting our initial hypothesis.

We applied the inductive method for the qualitative aspects of the study. This method is exploratory in nature and involves building theories or generalizations from specific observations. We began by immersing ourselves in the classroom setting without preconceived notions, using observation checklists and reflective notes to capture the nuances of student participation, engagement, and confidence during the co-teaching sessions. By analyzing these specific instances and patterns of behavior, we developed a deeper understanding of how the co-teaching strategies influenced the learning environment and facilitated oral communication. This descriptive method was essential for interpreting the human elements of the learning process that numbers alone cannot capture.

3.4. Data Collection Sources

To ensure a thorough and well-rounded analysis, we utilized a variety of data collection instruments designed to capture both quantitative and qualitative aspects of the students' progress and their experience with the co-teaching method. These instruments included pre- and post-test assessments, student surveys, classroom observations, and teacher reflections.

3.4.1. Pre- and Post-Test Assessments

To quantitatively measure the development of students' speaking skills, we administered individual oral production tests before and after the 8-week intervention. Each test consisted of a one-minute audio recording of the student. Given the students' beginner level, we did not provide a specific English prompt. Instead, to elicit their productive vocabulary, we prompted them in Spanish with broad, familiar topics such as "colors," "animals," "greetings," or "family." This allowed students to recall and produce any English words or simple phrases they knew. We then analyzed these recordings using the standardized rubric detailed in Appendix A to assess fluency, pronunciation, vocabulary, grammar, and confidence. This method provided measurable data on the change in their oral proficiency following the co-teaching intervention.

3.4.2. Student Surveys

We used two distinct surveys to gather students' perceptions of the learning experience. First, we administered the Student Self-Assessment Survey (Appendix C) on three separate occasions: at the beginning, midpoint, and conclusion of the study. This survey was designed to track the evolution of students' self-reported confidence, motivation, and perceived fluency throughout the intervention period. Second, at the very end of the research, we administered the Survey on the Effectiveness of Co-Teaching in EFL Classrooms (Appendix D).

3.4.3. Classroom Observations

To collect qualitative data on in-class behavior and interaction, we conducted systematic classroom observations during each of the 18 sessions with the experimental group. We used the Observation Checklist (Appendix B) to record data consistently across sessions. This instrument allowed us to document key indicators of engagement, such as whether students participated actively, responded in full sentences, used new vocabulary, and demonstrated confidence through body language and tone. These observations provided

rich, contextual data on how the co-teaching models influenced the classroom dynamics and students' oral participation in real-time.

3.4.4. Teacher Reflections

Teacher reflections served as an additional source of qualitative data, providing insight into the pedagogical process. These reflections were not recorded in a formal journal but were derived from two key activities. First, after each session with the experimental group, the collaborating teachers engaged in informal discussions to comment on the day's progress, challenges, and student responses. Second, we drew reflective data from the formal interview conducted with the lead teacher about the overall research experience. These combined reflections offered a professional perspective on the implementation of the co-teaching method and its perceived impact on both students and educators.

3.5. Research Design

We conducted this study using a mixed-method action research approach, which incorporated a quasi-experimental design. This framework was chosen as the most effective for achieving the study's dual objectives: first, to implement and evaluate a practical solution to a real-world problem within a specific classroom context (action research), and second, to measure the intervention's influence by comparing an experimental group with a control group (quasi-experimental design). The research took place at Escuela de Educación Básica "Victor Manuel Rendón," a public school in Valencia, Ecuador, which provided a realistic setting to test the co-teaching method.

The quasi-experimental structure involved the designation of two non-randomly assigned groups. The experimental group with 32 participants received instruction via the co-teaching method, while the control group with 30 students was taught using traditional, solo-teaching techniques. This comparative structure was fundamental for assessing the specific effects of the co-teaching intervention on students' speaking skills. The study was implemented over an 8-week period and involved a cyclical process to ensure continuous improvement and adaptation.

3.6. Research Instruments

To collect comprehensive data for this mixed-method study, we employed a suite of research instruments specifically designed to gather both quantitative and qualitative data. The use of multiple instruments allowed for a thorough triangulation of findings, ensuring that the study's conclusions were supported by diverse forms of evidence. The primary

instruments included a speaking assessment rubric, an observation checklist, student surveys, and teacher reflections.

3.6.1. Rubric for Speaking Assessments

We developed a standardized rubric to quantitatively assess student performance on the pre- and post-test speaking tasks. As detailed in Appendix A, this rubric evaluated four key criteria: Fluency, Pronunciation, Vocabulary & Grammar, and Confidence & Engagement. Each criterion was scored on a four-point scale ranging from "Needs Improvement" (1) to "Excellent" (4). This instrument provided a consistent and objective method for scoring the audio-recorded speaking samples, enabling a reliable comparison of student proficiency before and after the intervention.

3.6.2. Observation Checklist

For the qualitative data collection, we utilized an observation checklist to systematically record classroom dynamics during the co-teaching sessions. The checklist, presented in Appendix B, included specific, observable behaviors related to student participation (e.g., "Students participate actively in speaking tasks"), sentence construction, vocabulary use, and demonstrated confidence. We completed this checklist after each of the 18 instructional sessions with the experimental group to identify patterns in student engagement and monitor the immediate effects of the co-teaching strategies.

3.6.3. Student Surveys

We administered two distinct surveys to capture students' self-reported perceptions and attitudes.

The **Student Self-Assessment Survey** (Appendix C) was administered three times, at the beginning, middle, and end of the study. This tool used a Likert scale to track the evolution of students' confidence, motivation, and willingness to participate in speaking activities over time.

At the conclusion of the research, we administered the **Survey on the Effectiveness of Co-Teaching** (Appendix D). This final survey collected summative feedback, asking students to identify which co-teaching strategies they found most helpful and to reflect on the overall impact of having two teachers in the classroom.

3.6.4. Teacher Reflections and Interview

Teacher reflections provided a final, crucial layer of qualitative data. This information was captured through two primary activities. First, informal reflective discussions occurred between the collaborating teachers after each session to analyze classroom events, student progress, and pedagogical challenges. Second, we drew in-depth reflections from a semi-structured interview conducted with the lead teacher about her experience with the co-teaching partnership and its effect on the classroom environment.

CHAPTER IV

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

4.1. Discussion of the first specific objective

The successful fulfillment of the first objective, which was to construct a compelling theoretical rationale for the "co-teaching classroom," is evidenced in the comprehensive framework developed in Chapter II of this thesis. This foundational work successfully synthesized three critical pillars—foundational co-teaching models, the inherent complexities of speaking skill acquisition, and the specific pedagogical challenges within Ecuador—to propose a holistic and contextualized solution. The validity and relevance of this constructed rationale are significantly reinforced when analyzed alongside the research conducted by Pusedá Montenegro (2021), whose study on co-teaching as a strategy to develop speaking skills provides a vital point of comparison within the same national educational landscape. This discussion, therefore, illuminates how the established theoretical basis of the current study is not only internally coherent but also aligns with, and builds upon, existing scholarly work in the field.

A critical point of convergence between this investigation and the work of Pusedá Montenegro (2021) is the shared diagnosis of the core problem facing EFL students in Ecuador. This thesis identified systemic issues such as "overcrowded classrooms, severely limited instructional time, and a persistent reliance on traditional teaching methodologies" as primary barriers to oral proficiency. Echoing this, Pusedá Montenegro similarly highlights that "public classrooms are crowded all the time" and that these conditions hinder the development of language skills, particularly oral production. This parallel identification confirms that the challenges addressed are not isolated but are widespread pedagogical realities in the nation's public schools. By grounding the research in this shared problem, the proposed "co-teaching classroom" is validated as a response to a well-documented and persistent need, rather than a merely theoretical exercise.

Both studies are firmly anchored in the seminal work of Cook & Friend (1995), utilizing their definition of co-teaching as a partnership between professionals delivering instruction in a shared space. Furthermore, both this thesis and Pusedá Montenegro's research present the six foundational co-teaching models (e.g., Station Teaching, Parallel Teaching, Team Teaching) as the practical mechanisms through which this collaboration is enacted. However, a key distinction and contribution of the present study lie in its synthesis of these models into a singular, holistic concept: the "co-teaching classroom". Whereas Pusedá Montenegro (2021) examines the application of these strategies within an existing partnership, this thesis elevates them into a flexible and cohesive framework designed to be

intentionally implemented as a complete pedagogical system. This conceptualization moves beyond seeing co-teaching as a mere set of strategies and instead posits it as an integrated environmental solution.

Moreover, while Pusedá Montenegro's (2021) valuable research focuses on a specific context involving native-speaking volunteers from the "Peace Corp" program in Otavalo, the theoretical model developed in this thesis was intentionally constructed to be more broadly applicable. The "co-teaching classroom" is conceptualized as an adaptable framework that does not depend on the presence of foreign volunteers but can be implemented by any two collaborating educators, such as two local teachers or a general teacher and a language specialist. This distinction is pivotal; it means that the solution proposed in this study offers a sustainable and scalable model for the wider Ecuadorian public education system, which may not have access to such volunteer programs. This approach ensures that the benefits of co-teaching—reduced student-teacher ratios, increased student participation, and more individualized feedback—can be realized using existing human resources within the schools.

In conclusion, the construction of the theoretical rationale for the "co-teaching classroom" has been robustly achieved, satisfying the first specific objective. The logical synthesis of the challenges in Ecuadorian EFL contexts, the complexities of speaking, and the established models of co-teaching has resulted in a potent and relevant pedagogical proposal. The strong alignment with the findings and premises of Pusedá Montenegro (2021) confirms the timeliness and accuracy of the research problem and the chosen intervention. Ultimately, this solid theoretical foundation provides the necessary justification for the empirical phase of the study, which proceeded to test the practical effects of implementing this holistic model in a real-world classroom environment.

CHAPTER V

CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1. Conclusions**5.2. Recommendations**

CHAPTER VI

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CHAPTER VII

ANNEXES

7.1. Appendix A: Rubric for Speaking Assessments (Pre- and Post-Test)

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Good (3)	Developing (2)	Needs Improvement (1)
Fluency	Speaks smoothly with minimal hesitation and natural flow.	Mostly fluent with occasional pauses but maintains conversation.	Frequently hesitates, long pauses, disrupts communication.	Struggles to complete sentences, frequent breakdowns in speech.
Pronunciation	Clear and accurate pronunciation, few or no errors.	Mostly clear, with some mispronunciations but does not affect meaning.	Frequent pronunciation errors, sometimes affects understanding.	Many errors make speech difficult to understand.
Vocabulary	Uses a wide range of words, including some advanced expressions.	Uses an adequate vocabulary, with some variety in word choice.	Limited vocabulary, repeats simple words.	Very basic vocabulary, struggles to find words.
Grammar & Sentence Structure	Mostly correct grammar, varied sentence structures.	Some grammar mistakes but does not affect meaning.	Frequent grammatical errors, some misunderstandings.	Many errors prevent understanding, lacks sentence structure.
Confidence & Engagement	Speaks confidently, maintains eye contact, gestures, and natural intonation.	Speaks with some confidence, though some hesitation is noticeable.	Avoids speaking or requires prompting, speaks in monotone.	Very hesitant, avoids participation, little to no effort.

Scoring Guide:

- 16-20 points → Excellent
- 11-15 points → Good
- 6-10 points → Developing
- 0-5 points → Needs Improvement

7.2. Appendix B: Observation Checklist Template

Category	Yes	No	Comments
Students participate actively in speaking tasks.			
Students respond in full sentences instead of just words or short phrases.			
Students use both learned vocabulary and new expressions.			
Students show confidence when speaking (eye contact, gestures, appropriate volume).			
Students hesitate less than in previous lessons (reduction of long pauses or "uhh").			
Students ask and answer questions voluntarily.			
Students participate in pair or group speaking activities (conversations or collaborative tasks).			
Teachers provide immediate and useful feedback during speaking tasks.			
The co-teaching method increases student participation in speaking tasks.			
Both teachers collaborate actively during lesson delivery (interactions, role switching).			
Students show more motivation to participate in speaking activities due to the co-teaching approach.			
Students gradually improve in accuracy and fluency in speaking throughout the lessons.			
Students make use of different types of speaking tasks (debates, descriptions, presentations).			
Students interact effectively with their peers during group activities.			

7.3. Appendix C: Initial Student Self-Assessment Survey (change: pre-middle-post)

Instrucciones: Lee cada afirmación y marca (✓) la casilla que mejor describa cómo te sientes respecto a tus habilidades para hablar en inglés.

- 1. ¿Te gustaría mejorar tu habilidad para hablar inglés?**
☐ Sí, mucho ☐ Un poco ☐ No me interesa
- 2. ¿Sientes que tienes suficientes oportunidades para participar hablando inglés en las clases?**
☐ Sí, tengo muchas oportunidades
☐ Algunas veces tengo oportunidades
☐ No, casi nunca tengo oportunidades
- 3. ¿Sientes que en clase hay suficiente tiempo para que todos los estudiantes participen hablando en inglés?**
☐ Sí, siempre ☐ A veces ☐ No, casi nunca
- 4. ¿Te sientes motivado(a) a participar en actividades de habla en clase (diálogos o role plays)?**
☐ Me gusta y me siento motivado(a)
☐ A veces me da miedo, pero lo intento
☐ No me gusta para nada
- 5. ¿Te da miedo hablar inglés frente a la clase?**
☐ Sí, mucho ☐ A veces ☐ No, para nada
- 6. ¿Te gustaría recibir más retroalimentación sobre cómo mejorar tu pronunciación o fluidez al hablar inglés?**
☐ Sí, mucho ☐ Un poco ☐ No, no me interesa
- 7. ¿Te gustaría sentirte más seguro(a) al hablar inglés?**
☐ Sí, mucho ☐ Un poco ☐ No, no me interesa
- 8. ¿Qué tan cómodo(a) te sientes al hablar inglés con tu profesor y tus compañeros?**
☐ Muy cómodo(a) ☐ Más o menos cómodo(a) ☐ Muy incómodo(a)
- 9. En una escala del 1 al 5, ¿cómo calificarías tu nivel de confianza al hablar inglés?**
☐ 1 - Muy inseguro(a)
☐ 2 - Inseguro

☐ 3 - Más o menos seguro(a)

☐ 4 - Seguro

☐ 5 - Muy seguro(a)

10. ¿Crees que tus preguntas o dudas sobre el inglés son atendidas de manera rápida durante las clases?

☐ Sí, siempre

☐ A veces

☐ No, casi nunca

11. ¿Cómo te sentirías si pudieras recibir más atención individualizada mientras hablas inglés en clase?

☐ Me sentiría más seguro(a)

☐ No cambiaría mucho para mí

☐ Me sentiría incómodo(a)

12. ¿Te sentirías más cómodo(a) si hubiera un segundo profesor en el aula para ayudarte a participar más en las actividades de speaking?

☐ Sí, mucho

☐ A veces

☐ No, para nada

7.4. Appendix D: Survey on the Effectiveness of Co-Teaching in EFL Classrooms

Instrucciones: Esta encuesta tiene como objetivo evaluar el impacto de la co-enseñanza en el aprendizaje del inglés. Responde las siguientes preguntas según tu experiencia.

Parte 1: Selección Múltiple (Marca una respuesta por pregunta)

- 1. ¿Tener dos profesores en el aula te ayudó a mejorar tus habilidades para hablar en inglés?**
 - ☐ Sí, mucho
 - ☐ Sí, un poco
 - ☐ No, no realmente
 - ☐ No, no hizo ninguna diferencia
- 2. ¿Qué estrategia de co-enseñanza te pareció más útil para practicar el habla?**
 - ☐ Enseñanza Paralela (Grupos pequeños con diferentes profesores)
 - ☐ Enseñanza en Estaciones (Rotación entre actividades en grupos pequeños)
 - ☐ Enseñanza en Equipo (Ambos profesores trabajan juntos)
 - ☐ Enseñanza Alternativa (Apoyo extra para los estudiantes que lo necesitan)
- 3. ¿Con qué frecuencia sentiste que te animaban a hablar en clase con dos profesores?**
 - ☐ Siempre
 - ☐ A menudo
 - ☐ A veces
 - ☐ Nunca
- 4. ¿La co-enseñanza hizo que las clases fueran más dinámicas e interactivas?**
 - ☐ Sí, mucho

- ☐ **Sí, un poco**
- ☐ **No, no realmente**
- ☐ **No, para nada**

Parte 2: Respuestas Abiertas

- 5. ¿Qué fue lo mejor de tener dos profesores en el aula?**
- 6. ¿Qué se podría mejorar en la experiencia de co-enseñanza?**
- 7. ¿Recomendarías la co-enseñanza como método para otras clases de inglés? ¿Por qué o por qué no?**